Giving clear instructions in EMI

Practical guidance for subject lecturers - D01-S1–S5

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Students need to understand what a task requires before they can demonstrate their subject knowledge. These strategies help make instructions accessible while preserving the learning outcome and academic challenge. Select those appropriate to the task and your students.

1. Use clear, direct language

Start with the action students need to perform. Use short sentences and familiar, precise wording. Remove unnecessary introductory phrases and idioms. Keep essential subject terminology and explain it when it is new.

Original wording	Clearer wording
"*You are required to undertake a comparative evaluation of the two proposed pricing strategies, identifying the relative merits and limitations of each.*"	"*Compare the two pricing strategies. Identify the strengths and limitations of each.*"
"*Have a go at working out the total expenditure.*"	"*Calculate the total expenditure.*"

Preserve the thinking required. If students must evaluate and justify a decision, retain those actions: "Evaluate the two strategies using the criteria provided. Recommend one and justify your choice."

2. Break the task into steps

Number the actions in the order students should complete them. State who students will work with, how much time they have and what they need to produce. Keep the instructions visible while they work.

Example: an engineering task

1. Work in pairs. You have eight minutes.
2. Examine the circuit diagram.
3. Identify the most likely fault.
4. Use the diagram to explain your reasoning.
5. Write your proposed fault and explanation in three sentences.

For a longer activity, explain the overall purpose first, then give detailed instructions at each stage. Use the same wording when referring back to a step.

3. Demonstrate what to do

Show a short example of the process, using different content from the task students will complete. Explain your decisions aloud so students can see how to approach it.

Example: an accounting task
First, I read the transaction and identify what changed. Here, the business purchased equipment. Next, I identify the relevant accounts. I will show you how I record this transaction; you will then apply the process to a different transaction.

Demonstrate enough to make the process clear without supplying the answer or reasoning students are expected to develop independently. Ask students to identify the first step they will use in their own task.

4. Check that students know what to do

Ask specific questions about the instructions. These are often called instruction-checking questions (ICQs). They check the task requirements rather than subject understanding.

For the engineering task, ask:

- "*Are you working alone or in pairs?*"
- "*What will you identify*?"
- "*What must you include in your written response*?"
- "*How much time do you have*?"

Choose a few questions about details students could misunderstand. Invite answers from different students; a chorus of "*yes*" to "*Do you understand?*" provides little evidence.

For a more complex task, ask a student to explain the first step in their own words. If the answer reveals confusion, clarify the instruction and check again.

5. Check students' first attempts

Once students begin, look at several pairs or groups to see whether they have started as intended. Ask them to show their first step or explain what they are doing.

Example: *Show me where you think the fault is. What information from the diagram will you use to explain your choice*?"

Distinguish between two situations:

What you notice	What to do
Students have misunderstood the task requirements.	Clarify the relevant instruction. If the misunderstanding is widespread, pause and explain it to everyone.
Students understand the task but struggle with the subject content.	Provide a subject explanation, a prompt or another example appropriate to the intended learning.

Avoid repeating the entire instruction if only one detail is unclear.

Before your next lesson, choose one activity and check:

- Are the required actions easy to identify?
- Are essential subject terms retained and explained where necessary?
- Are the sequence, grouping, time and expected output clear?
- Would a short demonstration help?
- Which questions will check the instructions?
- What will you look for when students begin?

Supporting guidance

University of Minnesota, *Communication Tips*, particularly "Speak more effectively" and "Navigate communication styles";

TAEC Erasmus+ project (2017–2020), *EMI Handbook*, section 1.4.1, "Giving directions", pp. 19–20.

This draft brings together established guidance with original subject examples developed for the Inclusive EMI Guidance Toolkit.